



Kannan, turned out to be from Hyderabad. The 'home comfort' of a local boy is perhaps what Pondicherry was missing.

Dhruva Prasad

WHERE PERSISTENCE FINDS ITS PERCH

Nothing tests the Diary's thrift quite like a Ranji Trophy contest. In stark contrast to the neatly arranged press boxes at international or IPL games, the sidelines at India's premier First-Class competition are often bereft of comfort.

Such was the scene at the PCA New Cricket Stadium. The Diary sat under the shade of a mango tree, separated from the ground by a seven-foot fence, reduced to a mere accessory, waiting for the Punjab-Kerala clash to unfold on the B ground.

But this earnest backdrop of First-Class cricket spares no one, as the Diary was reminded when social media threw up an image of R.P. Singh, then a Mumbai Indians scout, watching a game from the same spot a year earlier.

So the Diary embraced the challenge, scouring the vicinity and making do with whatever it could find — a chair, a power socket, a stable internet line, anything.

Roughly 50 metres from the ground, the roof of the maintenance staff's office emerged as a sanctuary, offering a clearer view and a better mobile signal. From the confines of this 8x8 structure, the Diary worked on through four long days, quietly reminded that persistence matters off the field as much as on it.

Abhishek Saini

A TOUCH OF MCC AMID DELHI HAZE

Among the few dozen spectators scattered across the Old Clubhouse stand at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on the fourth day of the Ranji Trophy round-two match between Delhi and Himachal Pradesh was a family of four from



Stat file

Most Runs

Sanat Sangwan (Delhi) - 568 runs (Avg. - 142.00)

Karun Nair (Karnataka) - 488 runs (Avg. - 162.66)

Aman Mokhade (Vidarbha) - 439 runs (Avg. - 146.33)

Most Wickets

Arjun Sharma (Services) - 26 wickets (Avg. - 10.11)

Nikhil Kashyap (Haryana) - 20 wickets (Avg. - 11.40)

Siddharth Desai (Gujarat) - 20 wickets (Avg. - 15.55)

After three rounds of matches

England. On a hazy Delhi morning, they stood out easily — tourists at a low-profile domestic fixture, far from the glamour of international cricket. As Delhi's bowlers toiled to break the partnership between Ankush Bains and Pukhraj Mann before lunch, a man in a blue T-shirt and denim shorts was explaining field positions to his wife and two children. When he mixed up "point" and "cover," a few nearby journalists joined in, sparking a friendly exchange that revealed an unexpected cricketing link.

The man, Alex Robins, was visiting from London. His grandfather, Walter Robins, represented England in 19 Tests between 1929 and 1937 and captained in three against New Zealand. "My grandfather played against Sir Don Bradman," Alex said with pride.

Though Alex's own cricketing experience ended with college matches, his uncle Charles played First-Class cricket for Middlesex, and his 13-year-old son Ranulph is now a leg-spinner hoping to continue the family legacy.

"This is my second visit to India. We have come to Delhi on a holiday. We also visited Jaipur and Agra. I'm a member of the Marylebone Cricket Club (MCC) at Lord's," Alex said. "We found out that a match was taking place at the Kotla through the internet. We came just to enjoy some cricket."

For a quiet Ranji morning, it was an unexpected brush with cricketing heritage.

Vivek Krishnan

